



Partly sunny 65/45 • Tomorrow: Mostly cloudy 64/44 **B6**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

WEDNESDAY, MARCH 12, 2025 • \$4

House GOP circles the wagons on budget bill

Trump pushes holdouts as shutdown-thwarting measure heads to Senate

BY MARIANNA SOTOMAYOR

House Republicans have been incapable of passing a government funding bill without Democratic help since clinching the majority in 2022. That changed Tuesday — thanks, in part, to President Donald Trump.

The House approved a GOP proposal that would keep the federal government running through the end of September if the Senate adopts it before a 12:01 a.m. Saturday funding deadline. All but one House Republican voted for the bill, which passed 217-213.

With one exception, House Democrats rejected the continuing resolution, known as a CR, due to their opposition to cuts in government spending pushed by Trump and billionaire adviser Elon Musk through his U.S. DOGE Service.

The bill trims spending from fiscal 2024 by \$13 billion in non-defense spending over the rest of the fiscal year and increases defense funding by \$6 billion in an attempt to assuage hawks. It also includes more flexibility for the White House to direct funding, according to House GOP leadership aides, including an administration request for more money for Immigration and Customs Enforcement.

Benefits such as Social Security, Medicare and Medicaid wouldn't see any changes. But the bill would reduce funding for public defenders in Washington, D.C.,

SEE CONGRESS ON A17

Billion-dollar problem: D.C. says vote will devastate city services. **B1**



CARMEN YASMINE ABD ALI/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Russia's Wagner mercenaries bring 'catastrophe' to Mali

Fighting beside army, they massacre civilians and burn villages, say refugees in next-door Mauritania

BY RACHEL CHASON AND SARAH CAHLAN
IN BASSIKOUNOU, MAURITANIA

Kossi ag Mohamed, left, a 31-year-old herder who left Mali for Mauritania, said: "It is death that made me flee. I saw death everywhere."

his village in Mali's Timbuktu region. Wagner, he said, had brought "catastrophe."

Mali's military junta, which seized power from the democratically elected president in a coup d'état in 2020, began working with Wagner in late 2021. Nearly two years later, the future of the Kremlin-linked mercenary group was thrown into doubt when its founder, Yevgeniy Prigozhin, was killed in a plane crash after a short-lived rebellion against President Vladimir Putin.

But Wagner never went away, and its fighters have continued to deploy

SEE WAGNER ON A10

Education Department cuts nearly half of staff

BY LAURA MECKLER AND DANIELLE DOUGLAS-GABRIEL

The Education Department said Tuesday that it is cutting its staff by about half, a major step toward President Donald Trump's goal of shrinking the federal role in education and one that critics denounced as damaging to American children.

Trump has said he wants to eliminate the department altogether, but that is unlikely because it would require an act of Congress and 60 yes votes in the Senate, where Republicans hold only 53 seats. Absent that, the administration has been working to gut the agency by cutting grants and contracts and reducing staff.

The staff reductions announced Tuesday were the largest in department history and of a magnitude rarely contemplated before this administration took office. A senior official, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to describe details of the layoffs, said that every part of the department will be affected but also insisted that the reductions will not impact its ability to deliver services to student borrowers, to distribute grant money to school districts or to enforce civil rights law. She said all statutorily mandated

SEE EDUCATION ON A4

Trump casts, reels in Canadian steel tariff threat

BY DAVID J. LYNCH AND AMANDA COLETTA

President Donald Trump said Tuesday that he had ordered a doubling of the tariff on Canadian steel and aluminum, setting off a new wave of selling on Wall Street and raising fears that his insistence on overhauling the

global trading system may involve significant costs.

Then a few hours later, after financial markets convulsed, he told reporters he "probably" would not double down on the industrial metals tax after all.

Trump's initial midmorning threat came in response to Ontario Premier Doug Ford's imposi-

tion of a new surcharge on Canadian electricity supplied to three U.S. states. But Ford's action was itself a response to Trump's announcement last month of tariffs on foreign steel and aluminum, which were scheduled to take effect at 12:01 a.m. Wednesday and could cost Canada significant U.S. sales.

By day's end, it was not clear what the whiplash-inducing diplomacy had accomplished, other than to showcase the unpredictable character of Trump's policymaking.

It began with the president venting on social media and ended with one of his closest White

SEE TARIFFS ON A14



CAROL M. HIGHSMITH/LIBRARY OF CONGRESS

Federal artwork on its last leg?

Alexander Calder's sculpture "Flamingo" in Chicago is among the government-owned art pieces maintained by a division of the General Services Administration that is being slashed. **Story, C1**

NTSB urges banning certain helicopter flights near DCA

BY IAN DUNCAN AND LORI ARATANI

Citing "intolerable risk," federal investigators said Tuesday that certain helicopter flights should be permanently banned near Reagan National Airport, a recommendation that focused attention on the Federal Aviation Administration's inaction despite a history of close calls before a deadly crash this year.

The National Transportation Safety Board called for the restrictions on helicopter flight patterns as it released a preliminary report on the Jan. 29 collision of a U.S. Army Black Hawk helicopter and an American Airlines regional jet that killed 67 people.

The NTSB said the separation between helicopters and jets in the area was insufficient and posed "an intolerable risk to aviation safety by increasing the chances of a midair collision."

The board called on the FAA to quickly close a helicopter route along the eastern bank of the Potomac River when planes are using the runway involved in the crash and devise an alternative path for essential helicopter flights when the route is closed. The airport in Virginia is just over the river from D.C.

Temporary restrictions imposed after the crash have curtailed helicopter flights, and Transportation Secretary Sean P. Duffy said in response to the NTSB report that those restrictions will continue while under review.

Jennifer Homendy, the board's chair, said the FAA could have used the same data her investigators relied on to identify the risk and examine the helicopter routes before the crash occurred.

"It does make me angry, but it also makes me feel incredibly

SEE REPORT ON A17

USAID: Judge orders invoices be paid, okays halting contracts. **A9**

IN THE NEWS

Duterte arrested The former president of the Philippines, accused of the killings of thousands during his "war on drugs," was detained in Manila under an ICC warrant. **A12**

Falsified reports D.C. forensics lab workers covered up late arrivals at crime scenes nearly 700 times over a year, a review found. **B1**

THE NATION
Vice President JD Vance is quietly carving out a role in a crowded White House. **A4**
Critics say a federal crackdown on "sanctuary cities" harms other public safety efforts. **A7**

THE WORLD
Some of the Syrians working as doctors in Germany are weighing whether to go back. **A8**
A British couple were fined after calling the police on a migrant hiding on their RV. **A12**

THE ECONOMY
Amid a backlash over the slashing of the federal bureaucracy, the U.S. DOGE Service is on the hunt for "wins" it can promote. **A13**
The White House is transforming its traditional press shop into a rapid-response influencer operation. **A18**

THE REGION
With federal funding frozen for international exchange and study-abroad programs, American scholars overseas are in limbo. **B1**
D.C.'s archdiocese has a new leader in Cardinal Robert McElroy, a prominent advocate for immigrant rights. **B1**

STYLE
For Anas Baba, a Palestinian journalist at NPR, covering the war in the Gaza Strip also means living it. **C1**

FOOD
With the cost of real food rising, Lego eggs and balloon avocados are finding favor in TikTok recipe videos.

BUSINESS NEWS.....A13
COMICS.....C7
OBITUARIES.....B4
OPINION PAGES.....A19
TELEVISION.....C6
WORLD NEWS.....A8

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